



The contribution of community peace dialogue forums in peacebuilding and sustainable development in East Africa: A case study of peacebuilding initiatives between the Luo and Kipsigis communities of Kisumu and Kericho Counties, Kenya

By

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Abstract

Peace is a key variable as the enabling condition for sustainable development in any country. The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) cannot be achieved in the absence of peace. Through a case study of the protracted interethnic border conflict between the Luo of Kisumu County and the Kipsigis of Kericho County, Kenya, this study examines the power of community peace dialogue forums in promoting peace and sustainable development. The study adopted a qualitative research approach combining extensive literature review, in-depth, semi-structured oral interviews with key informants, focus group discussions (FGDs) and community engagements across Kisumu and Kericho Counties. Purposive and snowball sampling techniques were used to select 16 key informants and for one focus group discussion comprising eight individuals for the study. The study findings demonstrate that community-led peace initiatives can strengthen governance systems, empower grassroots communities and influence policy responses to conflict and violence. The paper concludes that a lasting solution to the conflict in the study area is possible through the activities of community peace dialogue forums. The study recommends that the National and county governments work together with the local communities and other stakeholders to address all the attendant issues in the conflict.

INTRODUCTION

Peace is an important enabling condition for the realization of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and it is a crosscutting issue which permeates all the 17 SDG goals. The pervasive environment of conflict, violence and insecurity in Africa poses a challenge to effective governance and development (Dorsouma, 2023). Africa continues to witness a surge of intrastate conflicts and violence, which have caused huge loss of human lives, horrific injuries, massive destruction of property, and a deluge of population displacement and refugee exodus in the continent. Such conflicts and violence pose a major challenge to United Nations' efforts to ensure global peace, prosperity and human rights for all under the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). These conflicts have seriously undermined African states' efforts to ensure long-term stability, prosperity and peace for its peoples. This vicious cycle of violence hinders progress towards the SDGs and undermines efforts to promote sustainable development.

Many African states have ignored a critical aspect of peacebuilding, which is ensuring the human security of all their citizens. Yet, peace is key for sustainable development. The African Union's 2063 Agenda and the "Silencing the Guns by 2020" initiative were adopted with the aim to deal with security challenges in Africa although the initial deadlines have passed and they did not properly deliver on their goals. As such, to get out of the quagmire of economic stagnation and underdevelopment peace is a prerequisite (Kuwali, 2022; McNamee & Muyangwa, 2021). The SDGs cannot be achieved when there is no peace. As such, it is imperative that the issue of peace in Africa be adequately addressed through effective and locally led peacebuilding initiatives and development process that take cognizance of the citizens' aspirations, thereby contributing toward the realization of SDG 16 which focuses on promoting just, peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development 'for all' by 2030 (MacNamee & Muyangwa, 2021).

Peace dialogues involve discussions between diverse stakeholders to manage conflicts and provide solutions to mitigate their causes (Chivasa, 2017; Nganje, 2021). These dialogues can be facilitated by peace mediators such as government officials, community elders, religious leaders, and other trusted figures. Studies have found that peace dialogues can be an effective strategy for conflict management, especially in situations where conflicting parties are not yet ready to engage with government agents. Local peace committees are structures formed at the grassroots levels with the aim of encouraging and facilitating inclusive peace making and peacebuilding processes within a local context (Odendaal, 2010). Issifu (2016) asserts that establishment of local peace committees help to institutionalize and legitimize traditional conflict resolution mechanisms. Community peace dialogue is one of the approaches that can be used to promote SDG Governance and coordination in Africa. Community peace dialogues are key strategic mechanisms for enhancing coordination across SDG efforts, especially in the realm of serving to align the various fragmented institutions, stakeholders, and policy responses. Apart from being a requisite for development, peace is a crosscutting issue just like gender mainstreaming which should be taken up by researchers to effectively address the prevailing situation in Africa. Peace dialogues can facilitate alignment between local communities, government institutions, civil society, and private sector actors (Bercovitch, et al., 2008; Tusso & Flaherty, 2016).

Scholars Paffenholz (2014), Issifu (2016), Chivasa (2017), Connolly and Powers (2018) propose the use of diverse peace initiatives such as local peace committees and community led peacebuilding networks in promoting sustainable conflict resolution. Through a case study of the protracted interethnic border conflict between the Luo of Kisumu County and the Kipsigis of Kericho County, Kenya, this paper demonstrates the power of community peace dialogue forums in enhancing peacebuilding and sustainable development in East Africa (Akinyi et al., 2011). It's worth noting that community peace dialogues tend to influence progress across interlinked SDGs, more so SDG 2 (food security and land use), SDG 6 (equitable water resource management), and SDG 16 (peace and institutional accountability). For example, resolving interethnic land conflicts (SDG 16) can improve access to farmland (SDG 2),

while inclusive dialogue around water-sharing agreements supports better Water Sanitation and Hygiene (WASH) outcomes (SDG 6).

Interethnic conflicts between the Luo and Kipsigis along the Kisumu County and Kericho County border have existed from time immemorial. The conflict can be attributed to a variety of causes such as boundary disputes, struggle to control pastureland, cattle rustling, negative ethnicity, political differences, poverty, as well as depletion of natural resources. The Luo-Kipsigis conflicts have intensified in the post-independence period due to the commercialization of cattle theft and other attendant factors. It has been a herculean task finding a lasting solution to these conflicts apparently because of recurrent cattle theft, which often leads to retaliatory attacks. It is evident that the 1990s new democratic openings in Kenya with the reintroduction of multiparty political system generated an unprecedented inter-ethnic and subethnic rivalry and struggle for political power, domination, and control of local and national resources in the country (Kagwanja, 1998).

In the last ten years or so Luo and Kalenjin elders have made numerous efforts to resolve the long-standing border conflict between the two communities. This has involved community peace dialogue forums, which is the focus of this research project. It has been difficult to foster long-term peace between these two communities, especially in the post-independence period because a myriad of factors have contributed to conflicts between them. The contribution of local peace dialogue forums as an initiative for peacebuilding in interethnic conflicts has not been adequately documented in literature hence this study.

Historical background

The early Luo settlers are believed to have entered the portion of Nyanza that lies north of the Winam Gulf (the current Siaya County) from eastern Uganda as part of a series of migrations of Nilotic-speaking people out of southern Sudan (Ogot, 1967). By the mid-eighteenth century, several Luo groups expanded out of this area and spread over South Nyanza as well. These ongoing population movements were halted by the imposition of British colonial control at the end of the nineteenth century when the territories of the various Luo subgroups at that moment were cartographically inscribed as the boundaries of the administrative sub-districts.

In the 19th century the Luo and the Kipsigis communities were in the process of settling in their present-day homeland hence the undefined colonial boundaries became the cause of contestation (Huntingford, 1953). The first reported serious border conflict between the two communities occurred in 1927 at Sondu. In 1963 there was another severe conflict between the Luo and the Kipsigis because of land problem. The colonial administrators took various measures to limit interethnic conflicts. From the early days of colonialism, one of the first measures that were undertaken by the colonial authorities was to forbid cattle raiding (Peristiany, 1939). This, however, did not stop cattle raiding during the colonial period. Nonetheless, as the colonial authorities extended their control over the Kenya highlands, large-scale cattle raiding reduced (Schiling & Opiyo, 2012). This was due to the strict measures put in place by the colonists to deter cattle thieves from raiding their neighbors. For instance, if an individual was found culpable of cattle theft he was punished severely, irrespective of where the offence had taken place (Schiling et al., 2012). In addition, the colonial government often used the mechanism of collective punishment to ensure that peace was maintained through group discipline.

Since time immemorial, along the Luo-Kipsigis border, the local inhabitants engaged in trading activities amongst themselves. The Kipsigis were known to have good quality livestock products like sour milk, hides and skins from goats and cattle respectively as well as salt lick which they exchanged with the Luo in the local markets (KII01, August, 2025). In the colonial times, Sondu market was the venue where all the commodities that were scarce in the area were availed to the others who had plenty of other products for exchange. Traders came with pots, baskets, iron implements, sorghum, potatoes, fish, bananas etc. Traders came from as far as Bomet and Kericho and brought

alongside them many iron implements to the market and sold them in exchange for other products that they themselves lacked.

From the 1970s, cattle rustling became endemic along the borderland. These raids often forced the local populations to flee from their homes and farms to safer grounds away from the borderland (KII11, August, 2025). It is also noted that school-going children are also affected by the displacement since most of them live with their parents. Schools such as Ngege, Holo, Ndori in Nyakach have very few pupils because of insecurity. In 1991 and 1992 there was serious violent conflict along the border which led to the deaths of dozens of individuals from both sides. It also led to the displacement of thousands of local people, burning of houses, looting of property and stealing of livestock (Akinyi et al., 2011; Kagwanja, 1998). It also affected the economic livelihoods of hundreds of traders doing business in Sondu and other borderland markets. This violence marked the period when multi-party politics was being re-introduced into the country for the first time during Moi's era. Different political parties were formed largely based along ethnic lines. The two communities supported different political parties (Kagwanja, 1998). The Kipsigis supported KANU while the Luo supported FORD.

It is worth noting that after independence, the Kisumu County Council still maintained the markets along the common border (KII11, August, 2025). They collected revenue in the markets and maintained the shades. Trade continued but quite often trade would be hindered by ethno-political conflicts and violence. This has led to a massive loss for the two communities given that the area is still largely underdeveloped. Many traders have been forced to relocate from Sondu to other townships such as Katito and Chabera in Nyamira County. As such, traders and investors fear operating their businesses in the volatile border area. This is one testament of how cattle rustling, conflict and insecurity have influenced the economy of the area thus contributing to poverty and underdevelopment. The county government and the National government also suffers losses in revenue collection. For example, for the last two years traders at Sondu market have not been paying county rates and market charges as they await the final decision by the National Land Commission on the recognized boundary of the two counties (KII11, August 2025).

Culturally, the Kipsigis believe that they were predestined to own cattle (Sands & Linda, 2010: 123). Generally, cattle had very high social value in the Kipsigis community. Thus, possession of many cattle was a sign of prosperity. As such, newly initiated Kipsigis warriors were culturally compelled to raid cattle because they demanded several animals to pay bride price. Retaliatory raids sometimes escalated to conflicts, especially if many animals were stolen and not recovered. At times, the Kipsigis warriors would link with Luo cattle thieves and transport the cattle to the border (KII11, August, 2025). When the cattle safely reached the boundary, the Kipsigis raiders would take the cattle and pay their Luo collaborators immediately or later as per their mutual agreements. Conflict frequently arose when animals were traced across the ethnic boundary and the Kipsigis resisted the recovery process or denied the existence of stolen animals in their territory (KII11, August, 2025).

Problem statement

Intermittent interethnic conflicts and violence between the Luo and Kipsigis along the Kisumu County and Kericho County border, especially in Nyakach and Sigowet-Soin Sub Counties, respectively have become endemic since the 1990s. The conflict has greatly contributed to loss of human lives, horrendous human injuries, stealing of livestock, destruction of property, including farmlands and food stores, perennial insecurity, which tends to curtail local inhabitants' agricultural activities and other forms of livelihoods as well as displacement of populations, among others. Various attempts have been made to manage the conflict but without much success. A number of community-based organizations in the two counties have made various attempts in spearheading peace-building efforts in the area but without much success. There is a paucity of studies done on the role of community peace dialogues in peace-building hence this study.

Purpose of the Study

The overall objective of the study is to examine the effectiveness and impact of community peace dialogues in promoting peace in the SGD Governance and coordination in Africa through a case study of Kenya.

Objectives of the study

- i. Explore the role of community peace dialogue forums in peace building among the Luo and the Kipsigis along the Kisumu-Kericho border, Kenya.
- ii. Establish the effectiveness of peace dialogue forums as alternative mechanisms for peace building in the Kisumu-Kericho border, Kenya.
- iii. Assess the impact of community peace dialogue forums in post-conflict reconciliation process among the Luo of Kisumu County and the Kipsigis of Kericho County, Kenya.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Akande, Kaye and Rukuni (2021) discuss the efficacy of community-based peacebuilding efforts to develop sustainable peace in conflict-torn communities using case studies from Nigeria and Zimbabwe. The authors have effectively applied participatory action research (PAR) by demonstrating how it can be used as a mechanism of developing durable solutions to a conflict: They contend that the approach provides the means to validate peace theories and draw upon a community's indigenous repertoire of knowledge and strengths to develop appropriate interventions. The scholars have used two case studies to explore broad principles that potentially can assist in the development of policies and practices. In the Nigerian case, two communities had experienced years of conflict.

Nganje (2021) reflects on the key role of local peace committees (LPCs) as mechanisms for peacebuilding in Africa. He notes that local peace committees have become the vogue globally against the undertones of changing conflict dynamics and a new peacebuilding discourse that has increasingly taken local dimension. The "localization" has given rise to diverse forms of grassroots peacebuilding initiatives. The author assesses the practices and evolution of LPCs in Africa over the past 30 years and affirms that there is need for greater regionalization of LPCs and a more enabling legal and policy framework to improve their continued efficacy. He demonstrates how LPCs have emerged as instruments that 'strengthen social cohesion and the resilience of local communities, thereby contributing to the search for sustainable peace beyond the immediate local environment.' Nganje further observes that Ghana is the first African country that has adopted measures to recognize, formalize, and incorporate LPCs into a national peace infrastructure from 2005 comprising national, regional, and district peace councils with mandates to facilitate dialogue, problem-solving, and reconciliation processes throughout the country. At the same time, the author avers that initial attempts to formalize LPCs in Kenya can be traced to 2001 when the government established the National Steering Committee on Peacebuilding and Conflict Management, whose mandate was formulating a national conflict management and peacebuilding policy, and coordinating various peacebuilding initiatives, including LPCs. However, following the destructive 2007 post-election violence Kenya adopted a more concerted effort to institutionalize a national peace architecture on the back of existing local peace structures.

Yorlay (2024) affirms that local peace committees (LPCs) are innovative and constructive means of resolving conflicts located within a community. He observes that there is strong evidence showing that when community members participate in the development and implementation of a solution, it is likely to be more durable. Similarly, Mac Ginty (2017) observed that to help in addressing local conflicts, LPCs have become necessary structures that incorporate customary and contemporary measures to inhibit, manage or transform conflicts within an ethnic group or involve

ethnic groups. Chivasa (2017) affirms that LPCs are important mechanisms to nib in the bud the outbreak or spread of low-level conflicts into vicious and more extensive conflicts and promoting development.

Arviola (2008) contends that LPCs reflect a community-based peacebuilding approach that uses innovative local means of social interaction, whose objective is rebuilding relationships, reducing violence, and fostering constructive social transformation. On the other hand, Yenika (2023) examines the process of community peacebuilding in addressing the Anglophone crisis in Cameroon. He affirms that community engagement is crucial in building sustainable peace in these regions because the community can better understand the root causes of the problem and identify locally appropriate solutions. He identifies the key stakeholders that could be engaged in the process of peacebuilding. These include religious leaders, traditional rulers, youths, women and civil society organizations. He recommends the development of peace education programs, the promotion of intercultural dialogue and the inclusion of women and youth in peace building efforts especially those residing in the communities .

Abdi and Mwangi (2023) assess the impact of community participation in peace building initiatives on inter-clan conflict management in Wajir county, Kenya. The authors demonstrate how peace dialogues in conflict management, and their absence could undermine government efforts to address conflicts like cattle rustling. The study demonstrates the potential of community involvement in various aspects of conflict management. It emphasizes the importance of dialogue, inclusivity, collaboration, equity, accountability, and prevention in promoting peace and addressing conflicts within Wajir County. Similarly, Barrow (2020) contends that inter-clan conflicts in Wajir County occur as a result of the political differences between clans. The political differences along clan lines, in a community with strong clan identities contribute to conflict escalations. Political leaders sometimes exploit the political differences between different clans for their own political expediency culminating to conflict escalations.

On the other hand, Karienyee and Warfa (2020) posit that challenges of resource distribution and equity in resources distribution is a key challenge leading to conflicts among pastoral communities of northern Kenya. Resource distribution challenges could be in terms of government resource distribution or access and exploitation of natural resources within the environment. Due to the different political inclinations and political access to power, some clans tend to have advantages in resources allocation from the government such as developmental projects hence leading to conflicts. The two scholars further assert that to achieve meaningful progress in conflict management, it is important to involve the local community in peace dialogues and to engage local leaders, clergy, and other professionals in areas prone to conflict. This is because the inclusion of community members in peace dialogues can also contribute to the sustainability of peace initiatives in the community Moreover, such peace building initiatives and community engagement in such undertakings are likely to serve to impact positively on the conflict management aspects.

Meanwhile, Marube (2022) examined the influence of peace dialogue to combat the cattle rustling menace among pastoral communities of north Rift region of Kenya. He contends that while the government had initiated diverse measures in dealing with the cattle rustling problem, the absence of peace dialogues between various stakeholders undermined the government's efforts in handling the cattle rustling problem. The study advocated for peace dialogue and community involvement in such dialogues to effectively deal with the cattle rustling challenges. He asserts that the informal peace dialogues and community participation in them could help the government achieve tangible progress in conflict management.

Kimokoti et al.(2016) discuss the role of peace dialogues as a mechanism of conflict management in the Kenya-Ethiopia cross border conflicts. The study identified numerous ways in which the peace dialogues impacted on conflict management. The authors aver that both the state and non-state actors must be involved in the peace dialogues. This then promotes communication aspects within the parties enabling the various parties feel engaged as community stakeholders in the peace dialogue activities. The community's involvement is therefore key in stakeholder management as it enables the building of the peace initiatives and the sustainability of such initiatives within the community.

Akinyi et al. (2011) assert that most conflicts in Nyanza and Rift valley emanates from three main causes, namely cattle rustling, land and politics. For example, among the Kipsigis and Luo, cattle rustling is the major cause of conflict,

which predates colonization. There is also an intricate relationship between environmental degradation and conflict. Cross border conflict between the two communities worsened with the introduction of multi-party politics, since they belonged to different political parties.

Atieno (2023) examined incidents and magnitude of resource- based conflicts in the Lower Nyando River Basin of Nyakach Sub County, Kisumu County, Kenya. He contends that existing peace initiatives such as local peace committees and community-led peace networks have effectively helped in addressing resource based conflicts in the area. The study concludes that local peace committees are accepted for the reason that they are formed by representatives of local social groups and they understand causes of resource based conflicts in the area well enough to aid transformation of the same.

Ethical considerations

The research complied with the necessary ethical norms during both data collection and processing. Safeguards were instituted to guarantee the preservation of the informants' privacy and confidentiality. All participants were granted informed consent before their involvement in the study. Data, comprising field notes, and transcripts, were securely stored, granting access exclusively to the researcher. Furthermore, participants were notified that all data would be used for academic purposes only.

Analysis of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) Tradeoffs

This section provides a brief discussion of trade-offs between SDG16 and SDGs 1 (poverty eradication), 2 (food security and land use), 4 (education for all) and 6 (water and sanitation). Although the Kenya Constitution guarantees the rule of law, human rights, and non-discrimination, hence a strong foundation for equality and justice, much still remains to be done. In the countryside people cannot access proper justice since justice is usually given to the highest bidder. Devolution has promoted equitable sharing of national resources, hence justice and institutional accountability. Devolution ensures that local residents manage local resources and prioritize their needs rather than being dictated to from Nairobi. It thus ensures local people participate in development planning and implementation as they are the masters of their destiny. Bangura, Gibbon, and Ofstad (1992) observed that to address interethnic conflicts, the state must promote economic development that take cognizance of the problem of marginalization, social inequalities, and political disequilibrium for development implementation. During the time when Kenya had a centralized government system there were numerous complaints that national resource allocation was skewed in favour of home areas of the president and other senior government officers.

Subsistence farming which is common in Nyakach and Sigowet/Soin Sub counties entrenches poverty in the population (SDG 1). Yet, if the local population shift to cash crops such as tea in Sigowet/Soin and cotton in Nyakach it will interfere with food security (SDG 2). Currently, Kenya faces fiscal limitations due to colossal national debt burden and limited tax revenues as evident in the recent price increase on petroleum products. Thus, during national budget making prioritizing which sectors to allocate the available meagre funds is an arduous challenge. As such, the government may act based on political expediency to prioritize direct, tangible poverty alleviation—such as cash transfers to the elderly (SDG 1) and food security measures (SDG 2)—at the expense of strengthening institutions such as Ethics and Anti-Corruption Commission (EACC) and justice systems (SDG 16).

SDG 16 focuses on peace, justice, strong institutions, inclusive societies and equal access to justice. The goals in Figure 1 support SDG 16 by reducing root causes of injustice and strengthening dignity, fairness and accountability.

Figure 1: SDGs 1,2,4 and 6 link to SDG 16

How SDGs 1, 2, 4 and 6 Link to SDG 16

Basic needs, dignity and inclusion create the conditions for peace, justice and strong institutions.



Table 1: Explanation of the Linkages

SDG	Main Focus	Link to SDG 16: Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions
SDG 1: No Poverty	Ending poverty in all forms.	Reducing poverty lowers exclusion, vulnerability and inequality. This improves access to public services and justice, and supports peaceful, inclusive societies.
SDG 2: Zero Hunger	Ending hunger, improving food security and nutrition, and supporting sustainable agriculture.	Food security reduces instability and social tension. Fair access to food and agricultural support strengthens dignity, equality and trust in institutions.
SDG 4: Quality Education	Inclusive and equitable quality education and lifelong learning.	Education builds rights awareness, civic participation, critical thinking and accountability. It helps citizens engage peacefully and demand fair institutions.
SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation	Availability and sustainable management of water and sanitation for all.	Fair access to water and sanitation protects human dignity and reduces conflicts over basic resources. It also depends on accountable service delivery.

SDG 16: Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions	Inclusive societies, justice, accountable governance and strong institutions.	SDG 16 is strengthened when poverty, hunger, poor education and lack of clean water/sanitation are addressed, because these conditions directly affect fairness, stability and public trust.
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The government has continued to employ more judges and magistrates as a mechanism for resolving disputes and ensuring justice to Kenyans (SDG 16). This is a positive move since justice delayed is justice denied. It's worth noting that to secure peace and justice (SDG 16) there is need for more robust community policing and legal protections. Yet, when poverty remains high as is the case in Nyakach and Sigowet/Soin Sub Counties, standing at 36.8% and 39.1% respectively, resources are often diverted to deal with emergency social relief, especially after disasters such as floods, droughts etc and policing civil unrest such as workers strikes rather than toward building long-term, accountable institutions such as EACC (SDG 16). Justice can then be sacrificed at the altar of short-term political benefits. Moreover, the high poverty rates (SDG 1) and youth unemployment in the two sub counties create desperation, leading to increase in crime and ethno-political tensions. The Children's Act clearly aim at ensuring that the interests of the child is respected at all times (SDG 4). Yet emphasis on children's rights may also interfere with poverty eradication measures in terms of resource allocations (SDG 1).

Under the new constitution Kenya has a two-tier government system namely; national and county governments. The national government is in charge of key government departments thus it faces a challenge in ensuring fair distribution of resources. For example, allocating more funds to poor counties like Kisumu to eradicate poverty (SDG 1) in Nyakach may often incapacitate national institutions expected to monitor, audit, and prosecute the misuse of devolved funds, which to a large extent undermines SDG 16's goal of reducing corruption and building transparent institutions. Very often giving priority to one SDG will adversely affect another SDG hence the need for trade offs.

Research methodology

Study location

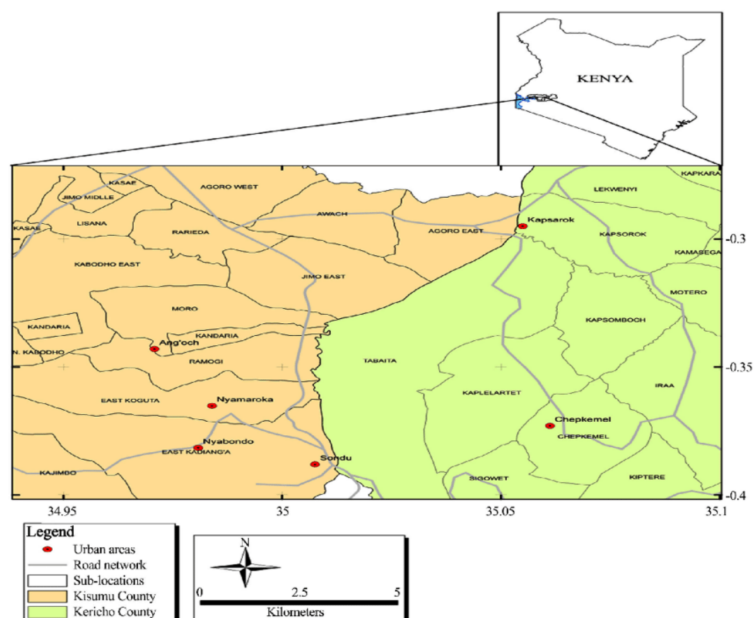
The study was conducted in Nyakach Subcounty of Kisumu County and Sigowet Sub County of Kericho County, Kenya (see Map 1 and Map 2). Nyakach Sub-County administrative headquarters are in Pap Onditi. The sub-county is subdivided into five wards—North Nyakach, Central Nyakach, West Nyakach, South East Nyakach, and South West Nyakach—each serving as an electoral unit for devolution. On the other hand, the administrative headquarters of Sigowet-Soin Sub County is Kipsitet trading centre. The sub county has four wards namely: Sigowet, Kaplelartet, Soliat and Soin (NGCDF, Sigowet-Soin Report, 2023).

According to the 2019 Kenya Population and Housing Census conducted by the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS), Nyakach Sub-County, had a total population of 150,320- people, comprising 71,237 males and 79,082 females. Nyakach is predominantly inhabited by the Luo ethnic group, with minority groups including Abagusii, Kalenjin, Nubian, Kikuyu and Somali communities. On the other hand, Sigowet-Soin Sub-County has a population of 126,500 (see Table 2). Urbanization remains low in both sub counties, with over 90% of residents in rural settings (Population Census, 2019).

Table 2: Nyakach and Sigowet Counties' population (2019)

Sub County's name	Male	Females	Total
Nyakach	71,237 (47.4%)	79,082 (52.6%)	150,237
Sigowet/Soin	63,103 (49.9%)	63,103 (50.1%)	126,500

Map 1: Study area



Source: Juma, J.O & Simiyu R. (April 2018). The nexus between socio-economic environment and recurrence of interethnic conflicts in Nyakach and Sigowet sub counties of western Kenya. *International Journal of Social Science and Humanities Invention*.

Map 2: Nyakach sub county townships



Source: Adapted from Nyakach Constituency Development Plan, 2022

Socioeconomic characteristics of the study area

Nyakach Sub County is predominantly agrarian, with smallholder subsistence farming forming the backbone of livelihoods (Kisumu County Fact Sheet, 2024). Primary crops include maize, sorghum, and beans, cultivated on small plots. Livestock rearing complements crop farming. Livestock comprises cattle, sheep, goats, and chickens. Aquaculture including pond-based fish farming producing species like tilapia has also gained prominence in the sub county. There is also small scale sugarcane and rice cultivation in some areas. Small-scale trade in farm produce is also part of the local economy. Poverty in Nyakach Sub-County aligns with broader rural patterns in Kisumu County,

where absolute poverty levels stand at approximately 36.3% of the population (KIPPRA, 2024). On the other hand, 30.6% of the population of Sigowet-Soin live in absolute poverty (Kenya Population Census, 2019).

Table 3: Socio-economic activities in Nyakach Subcounty

S/No	Activity	Participation rate
1	Agriculture	Very high
2	Agropastoralism	High
3	Fishing	Moderate
4	Poultry keeping	Moderate
5	Aquaculture	Moderate
6	Petty trade	High
7	Formal employment	Low
8	Informal sector employment	Very high
9	Casual labour	High

Source: Author, May 2026

Similarly, in Sigowet-Soin Sub-county farming is the most leading economic activity in this area; majority of the people have farms where various agricultural activities going on (County Government of Kericho, 2025). Farming activities in the subcounty encompasses livestock keeping which is key as the Kipsigis have a lot of socio-economic attachment to the cows for milk production. Inhabitants grow food crops while tea cultivation is thriving in some parts of the sub county. In addition, sugarcane farming is also carried out in some parts of the sub county. A sugar mill processing plant is also under construction in Soin area. Two industries namely Rai Cement Factory and Prime Steel Mills are operating in the area thus providing job opportunities for the local population. Farm leasing at a fee by individuals with large trucks of land is also common (NGCDF, Sigowet-Soin Report, 2024).

Apart from agriculture, business is an important economic activity in the study area (Government of Kericho County, 2025). Common business activities are; sale of farm produce, petty trade, *boda boda* (motorcycles) and other related trading activities from various parts of the two sub-counties as well as other areas such as Homa bay and Nyamira Counties. Sondu market is a key market place that hosts people from Kericho, Kisumu, Nyamira and Homa Bay Counties for trade and related business, especially during three market days weekly. Since formal employment is low most people are engaged in informal employment including casual farm labourers, sugar cane cutters, tea pickers, sand harvesters, quarrymen and fishermen.

The periodic ethnic conflicts and tension in the borderlands have a huge impact on the economic activities in the area. As one participant posited, “ I am one of those people who had been displaced during such conflicts and my family relocated elsewhere. As a young entrepreneur I have witnessed businesses collapse and most businessmen incur great losses’ (KII14, January 2026). The perennial Sondu violence is a major loss to the community given that the area is still largely underdeveloped. Many traders have been forced to relocate from Sondu to other townships such as Katito and Chabera in Nyamira County. As such, traders and investors fear operating their businesses in the volatile border area. Moreover, the county government and the National government also incur losses in revenue collection. For example, for the last almost two years traders at Sondu do not pay any county rates and market charges as they await the final decision by the National Land Commission on the recognized boundary of the two counties (KII11, August 2025).

Table 4: Socioeconomic activities in Sigowet/Soin Sub County

S/No	Activity	Participation rate
1	Agriculture	Very high
2	Tea farming	Moderate
3	Sugarcane farming	Moderate
4	Agropastoralism	Very high
5	Petty trade	Moderate
6	Formal employment	Low
7	Informal sector employment	High
8	Casual labour	High
9	Farm leasing	Moderate

Source: Author, May 2026

Data collection methods and techniques

This study is exploratory in nature and has employed a predominantly qualitative approach based on case study design. It incorporated extensive use of literature, focused group discussions (FGDs) and in-depth, semi-structured oral interviews with key informants as well as community engagements across the study area. The strengths of this approach derive mainly from its inductive approach, its focus on specific situations, of people and its emphasis on words rather than numbers. At the same time it allowed flexibility in data gathering (Taylor et al., 2015). Since the study focused on capturing the experiences of individuals involved in peace building through their own voices and expressions, qualitative research method was deemed appropriate (Creswell & Cresswell, 2022). Furthermore, qualitative research can help obtain the insider's view of situations and events, revealing the extent of the problem, while presenting an in-depth understanding of the situation as well.

The population of the study comprised 16 residents of Kisumu and Kericho Counties. This study being qualitative research, relied on a small sample size of 16 participants that was justified by combining the principle of data saturation through purposive and snowball sampling techniques (Creswell & Cresswell, 2022). According to Braun and Clarke (2021), qualitative data collection typically requires fewer participants than quantitative research, as the aim is to reach data saturation. The researcher can probe more deeply into responses, seeking clarification and elaboration on key issues (Cresswell & Creswell, 2022; Taylor et al., 2015)). Research participants were chosen from individuals of diverse backgrounds but involved in peacebuilding initiatives, among them community elders, peace ambassadors, women leaders and youth. The selected group provided a representative sample from the Luo and Kipsigis ethnic communities. Purposive sampling method helped the researcher gather detailed responses from participants considered to be very familiar with the subject of peacebuilding in Kisumu-Kericho borderland. Through snowball sampling technique the researcher managed to access additional knowledgeable individuals for interviews.

Key informant interviews was adopted as data collection method because it enables participants to convey their experiences and viewpoints comprehensively and genuinely, for better understanding of the topic (Taylor et al., 2015). The interview questions covered peacebuilding, social development goals and sustainable development.

Figure 2: Participants' age distribution

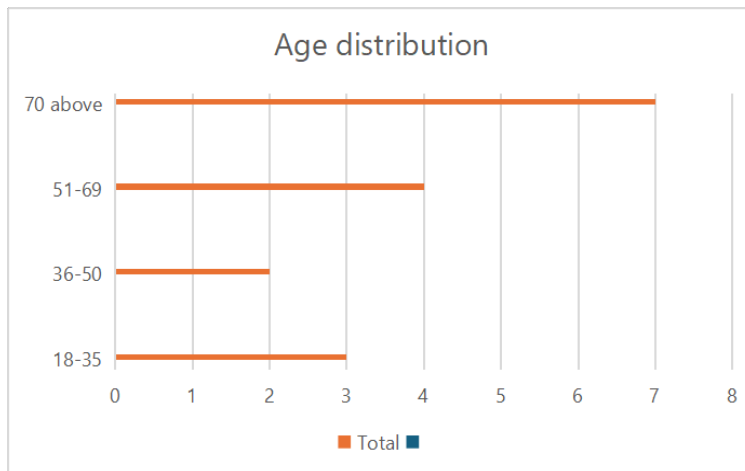
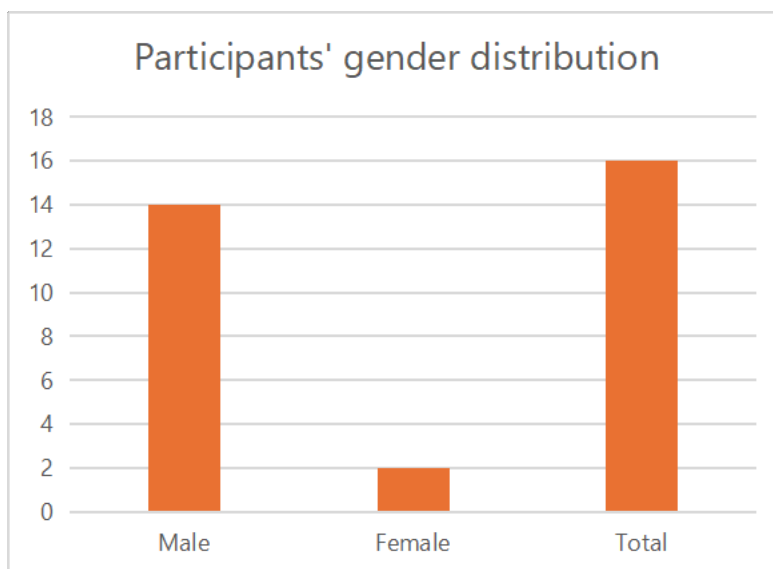


Figure 2 provides participants' age distribution. It shows that almost half of the participants were 70 years and above. These are elderly individuals with vast experience and indigenous knowledge on conflict and peacebuilding activities in the study area.

Data was gathered via individual key informant interviews in which individuals responded to a series of open-ended questions (see Appendix A). The interviews were conducted in person at venues selected by the participants to ensure their comfort and safety. Each interview lasted 45 to 60 minutes, providing participants sufficient opportunity to convey their viewpoints in a relaxed environment. For ease of communication, all interviews were conducted in the individuals' preferred vernacular language, Kiswahili or English. After the interviews, the field notes were meticulously updated, preserving the integrity of the participants' emotions and insights. Utilizing Braun and Clarke (2021) qualitative methodology, the data collection aimed to obtain comprehensive, detailed narratives from participants to investigate the intersections of peacebuilding and SDGs.

Figure 3: Participants' gender distribution



In terms of gender, Figure 3 shows that women’s participation in community peace dialogue forums is still rather low. Out of the 16 key informants, only two were women. The numerous efforts by the research assistant to get more women informants did not materialize. The low number of women’s involvement is attributed to cultural and social reasons.

The research also utilized one focus group discussion (FGD) and secondary sources as additional sources of information to gather sufficient data for the study. In the FGD eight individuals were selected from the two communities. The FGD was held at Sondu township. The sampled population were residents of the area during the period of the study. The researcher considers this sample population to be suitable and significant because they are involved in the community peace dialogue forums, hence in a position to provide the study with valuable information. FGDs can aid in gathering information about the contribution of the forums in peace building in the borderland.

The reviewed literature sources provided relevant historical, political, and demographic background information on the two counties, and they were particularly useful for corroboration, comparison and designing research tool for fieldwork. In addition, the study used community engagement to collect additional data. Community engagement involves ensuring public participation in decision making. This took the form of informal and formal meetings with community members at various events. It encourages cooperation with the community, especially in decision making (Hirst, 2021). It’s worth noting that citizen engagement or involvement in an activity or project including research has positive impact on the success of the activity/project. Basically, it aims at ensuring, safeguarding the project to ensure its sustainability Effective community engagements places the community at the core of decision-making process through public mobilization and participation (Hirst, 2021).

Figure 4: Participants’ education level

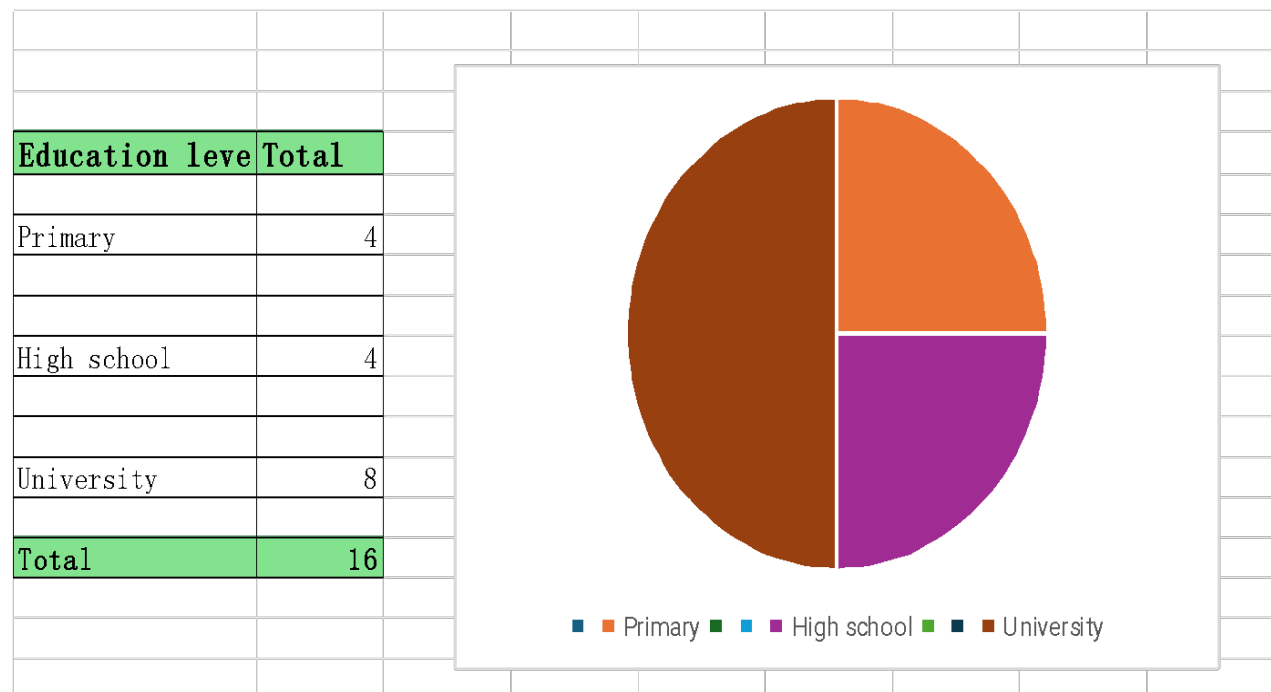


Figure 3 shows that the key informants were generally an enlightened group given their educational level. Half the key informants were university graduates with the other half being primary school and high school level. Consequently, the participants were able to effectively articulate issues during the interviews.

Data transcription and analysis

Data transcription and analysis commenced with multiple reviews of audio recordings, supplemented by comprehensive notes taking to document early thoughts and findings, concentrating on carefully capturing all nuances, with particular emphasis on the participants' language, tone, and context. While listening to each recording, the researcher documented each emerging theme or pattern.

In the second step of the study, the researcher manually transcribed the data by re-listening to the recordings, translating from local language into English where necessary. Transcription involves converting raw audio or video data into written text, thus facilitating easier coding and interpretative analysis. It enables a researcher to systematically examine and interpret the data, accurately and enhancing the overall rigor of the study (Cresswell & Creswell, 2022). During this phase, the researcher compiled analytical notes that documented notable or recurring themes, which were cross-referenced with the initial listening notes. These comments were crucial for aiding interpretation of the data in later phases. The interviews were transcribed and coded to check the adequacy and consistency of the themes (Cresswell & Creswell, 2022; Taylor et al., 2015). Thereafter, the data was classified into several coding categories and themes (See Table 5) in relation to the research objectives. Coding categories were used to sort the descriptive field research data. During the data analysis the researcher read and reread the transcripts, marking out important points, ideas, and looking for emerging patterns and linkages.

On issues where there was disagreement among participants, the extensive field notes gathered during key informant interviews were crosschecked with secondary data and FGD data for corroboration purposes through triangulation (Creswell & Creswell, 2022). This was done to remove any bias and to ensure accuracy and reliability. Since the researcher wanted to discern the general patterns and dominant themes as set on the objectives, repetition of data was looked for. Careful re-reading of both field notes and other secondary data were helpful in unearthing significant patterns. As such, ideas or aspects that seemed to fit together and reinforce each other were regarded to be more significant and given priority than the isolated ones.

The researcher utilized a manual approach for analysis of interview and FGD data rather than software because of the small number of study participants numbering 24 individuals. It started with listening to audio recordings Cypress (2019) observes that although software powered coding has gained currency, qualitative data coding still be carried out manually. Similarly, Basit (2003: 152) opined that “the use of software may not be considered feasible to code only a few interviews” since the software licence is costly. By using MS Word as a manual coding tool, the researcher employed the technique of “cut and paste” and highlighting to categorize and analyze data (Cypress, 2019). By coding text into specific themes on separate MS documents, with codes corresponding to headings, the researcher managed the data efficiently. The researcher developed the following nine codes from the interview schedules and FGD as listed in Table 5.

Table 5: Data codes, themes and subthemes

S/No	Code	Theme	Subthemes
1.	Interethnic conflicts	Causes of interethnic conflicts in Nyakach-Sigowet/Soin Sub Counties	Poverty Border issue Cattle rustling Political incitements Land Control of resources
2.	Socioeconomic conditions	Economic characteristics Population status Sources of income	Forms of employment Feelings of economic marginalization

3.	Gender	The role of women in peacebuilding	Challenges facing women in peacebuilding
4.	Peacebuilding	Peacebuilding initiatives The role of community peacebuilding forums to peace	Peacebuilding stakeholders Justice and peacebuilding Impact of peacebuilding
5.	Ethnicity	The role of ethnicity in conflict & peacebuilding	Forms of ethnicity Negative vs positive ethnicity Addressing ethnicity
6.	The youth	The role of the youth in conflict & peacebuilding	Challenges of youth in peacebuilding
7.	Culture	The contribution of culture to conflict & peacebuilding	Culture and cattle rustling Indigenous knowledge and practice
8.	Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)	The link between SDGs & development The role of NGOs/CBOs/religious institutions in peacebuilding.	SDGs 1,2, 4, 6 & 16
9.	Politics & governance	The role of multiparty politics in conflict Political mobilization	Political differences and conflict Political competition and peacebuilding

The data was analyzed utilizing thematic approach, adhering to Braun and Clarke's (2021) six-step methodology based on the research objectives to determine trends and patterns that were related to the variables under study. The procedures employed in this process were as follows:

1. Acquaintance with the Data: The researcher commenced by attentively reading and re-reading the interview transcripts to really engage with the data. This enabled me to acquire a comprehensive understanding of the principal topics and themes that surfaced from the participants' narratives.

2. Creating preliminary codes: In this phase, the researcher carefully analyzed the data and allocated preliminary codes to text parts that encapsulated essential information. The codes were derived from recurring patterns, concepts, and replies that pertained to the research issues, specifically with the nexus of interethnic conflict and peacebuilding. First, the researcher chose to generate themes and subthemes from the research questions rather than the objectives. Second, there were additional themes and subthemes which emerged from the interview guides that did not fit into those generated from specific objectives or research questions. These were incorporated as additional themes or discarded.

3. Exploring themes: At this juncture, the researcher categorized similar codes into overarching themes that encapsulated the fundamental difficulties within the data. Themes included participants' personal experiences and the systemic issues affecting interethnic relations and peacebuilding in the borderland. The researcher also checked on biases and divergent opinions of participants. Selection of final study findings were based on preponderance of evidence/data. After identifying the deductive themes and subthemes, the researcher clearly connected the themes and subthemes to relevant data sources from the interview guides (see Table 6), whose responses provided data related to the generated themes and subthemes. This process necessitated a careful review of the interview guides to locate relevant sections and responses that align with the preliminary themes and subthemes. All subthemes related to a similar theme were considered together. This thorough mapping ensured that data coding was systematic and that each theme and subtheme was adequately explored, thereby enhancing the study's overall rigor and coherence (Table 3).

4. Evaluating the themes: The themes were evaluated and enhanced to guarantee they precisely reflected the data. This procedure entailed verifying the consistency of the themes with the coded data and confirming their alignment

with the overarching narrative of the research. After mapping themes and subthemes to their corresponding data sources, the researcher developed guided transcription templates for the key informant interview guide to facilitate easy coding and for consistency. Using guided templates help maintain the integrity of the data, ensuring that the responses remain aligned with their designated themes and subthemes.

5. Establishing and designating themes: The researcher defined and designated each one to accurately express the essence embodied by each theme. Significant categories emerged, including "ethnicity and politics", "peacebuilding initiatives" as well as "gender and peacebuilding", among others.

6. Generating the Report: The concluding phase entailed documenting the findings in a manner that emphasized the perspectives of the participants while concurrently linking their experiences to overarching sustainable development goals. Differences or disagreements among participants were considered and decided based on preponderance of evidence in favour of majority views. In addition, differences were sorted out through corroboration, i.e. evidence was confirmed with other sources such as written documents and FGD. This was a form of using triangulation procedures.

Table 6: Descriptive coding

Themes and Subthemes and Supporting Quotations from KIIs and FGD

Theme	Subthemes	Quotations
Socio-economic factors	Politics & governance	"Community peace dialogue forums bring people together and ensures that their voices are heard." (KII08, August 2025)
	Land & border issue	"Make known clearly the boundary demarcations between Kisumu and Kericho Counties to end the border dispute." (KII08, August 2025)
	Poverty	"The poverty rate in both Nyakach and Sigowet-Soin Sub Counties is very high, which contribute to idleness among the youth who tend to engage in cattle rustling and other forms of violence in the area." (KII11, August 2025)
	Revenue	"One of the major causes of the conflict is desire to control the high revenue collected at Sondu market." (KII11, August 2025) "The main cause of Sondu conflict is revenue collection dispute i.e. both Kericho and Kisumu Counties have

Theme	Subthemes	Quotations
		differences on who to collect revenue and upto what part of Sondu.” (KII07, August 2025)
Cultural beliefs and practices	Cattle rustling	“ The main causes of the conflict are stock theft, political differences and border dispute.” (FGD, January 2026) “These conflicts can be resolved if the Kipsigis cultural beliefs about cattle rustling are demystified” (FGD, January, 2026)
Peacebuilding & development	Community dialogue forum Peacebuilding initiatives	“Community peace dialogues are good as they provide a neutral platform where stakeholders can share needs and plans of creating peaceful coexistence in the area.”(KII07, August 2025) “ The forums have given the local community a voice in identifying conflict triggers and come up with their own solutions.” (FGD, January 2026) “The dialogues have helped rebuild trust between the two communities and also promoted peaceful coexistence.” (FGD, January 2026) “Sometimes we encountered hostilities from individuals opposed to peaceful coexistence of the two communities.” (KII01, August 2026) “ Most of the peacebuilding initiatives have been unsuccessful except for a few that involved the youth. Many elders have shown dishonesty at some point making the exercise futile.” (KII010, FGD)

	Peace & Development	“Definitely, I feel that peaceful coexistence is the only way to achieve SDGs.” (KII08, August 2025) “I fully agree. Whenever there is violence in Sondu, schools area closed and business stops, which hinders socioeconomic development.” (KII09, August 2025) “I agree that for the achievement of SDGs there must be peace.” (KII010, August 2025)
	Post conflict reconciliation	“The peaceful coexistence of the two communities at Sondu” (KII02, August, 2025)
Gender & peacebuilding	The role of women	“Women have participated in organizing peacebuilding initiative program at Sondu.” (KII03, August 2025) “In some instances, women get discriminated against while some lack the courage to stand and talk about conflict and peacebuilding.” (FGD, August 2025) “I and other women have been spearheading peacebuilding dialogues in the area and in fact I have been nominated for a presidential award at one time.” (KII08, August 2025)
The youth & peacebuilding	The place of the youth in peacebuilding	“We organized and attended the Kisumu-Kericho border tournament in December 2025 and I feel it was fruitful. It brought a lot of interaction between the two communities.” (KII04, August 2025)

SDGs &
peace

SDGs

linkage

“Jobless youths are normally the propagators of conflict in the borderland.”
(KII08, August 2025)

“It’s true that in the absence of peace SDGs cannot be achieved in any society.” (KII01, August 2025)

“ To achieve the SDGs the government should unite all the local people regardless of gender and ethnicity to champion for peace.” (KII08, August 2025)

“Community dialogue forums create peaceful harmonious coexistence and spurs economic growth thereby enhancing livelihoods.”(KII08, August 2025)

Lastly, the researcher went through the field data and then extracted excerpts or relevant information to illuminate the discussion. In most instances, the researcher provided verbatim quotations to make strong arguments. This method provided ways of discerning, examining, comparing and contrasting, and interpreting meaningful patterns or themes on which study conclusions were drawn.

FINDINGS AND DISCUSSIONS

The study made five key findings as discussed below.

Causes of the Luo-Kipsigis conflict

The study has established that conflicts between the Luo of Nyakach and the Kipsigis of Sigowet-Sondu Sub Counties still persist. Thus, insecurity associated with cattle rustling and land disputes are still evident in the study area. This is attributed to rival claims of ownership by the conflicting groups. This finding concurs with earlier studies conducted in the area (Atieno, 2023; Akinyi et al., 2011). It’s worth noting that conflicts between the Luo and Kipsigis began in the pre-colonial period mainly due to cattle rustling. In the pre-colonial era, Luo and Kipsigis communities coexisted peacefully. For example, they exchanged goods and services along their common border. However, the peaceful co-existence between these two communities was often disrupted with sporadic conflicts. Land was one of the major contentious issues in the area, especially along the boundary of the two sub-counties. One of the participants posited that people who had bought land along the border on the Sigowet/Soin Sub-County side were frequently attacked and their houses set on fire during the clashes. Such incidences intensified ethnic animosity.

Akinyi et al. (2011) affirms that inter and intra community land disputes were frequent due to scarcity of land as well as lack of clear demarcation of boundaries which inhibited community members to have mutual agreements on the boundaries, hence the protracted nature of Sondu land conflicts. In Sondu township zone where the protracted land problem is perennial, the Kipsigis believe that the Abagusii and Luo have encroached into their land and they are

obligated to defend the land. The Luo and the Kisii on the other hand argue that they have purchased the land through willing -buyer willing-seller deals.

The study established that local politicians, especially members of parliament and county assemblies, tend to inflame the conflict. These politicians are accused of politicizing the issue by inciting their community members thus torpedoing conflict resolution initiatives. The Luo from Nyakach sub county and the Kipsigis from Sigowet-Soin sub-county both cherish agriculture and specifically livestock rearing as an economic activity, therefore stealing of livestock impedes people's livelihoods and can be a cause for mobilization among members of either community to retaliate. During the periods of these conflicts or tension following these conflicts, other economic activities such as trade are negatively affected. During violent periods people neither attend to their farms nor go to the market to earn their incomes which negatively affects the economic status of the residents. One of the impacts of frequent conflicts is burning of shelters which include burning of food stores thereby affecting people's subsistence. The fact that crop farming and livestock rearing are the major economic activities in the area therefore gives an indication that there is a lot of pressure on land and the need for livestock as the key source of wealth among residents of the two sub counties. The Kipsigis' cultural practice of cattle rustling therefore is a major cause of the incessant conflicts.

Consequently, inter-ethnic mistrust between the two communities in the study area is rampant. Repeated incidences of violence by one ethnic group targeting another ethnic group tends to lead to a situation of mistrust thereby culminating to a situation where members of each ethnic community develop siege mentality and look at the other as enemy. Gurr (2000) correctly observes that once conflicts breaks out, ethnic identities and hatred tend to become entrenched making cooperation and coexistence between the groups even more difficult, hence the continuous conflict cycle. As such, it is apparent as noted by Kumssa, et al (2009) that apart from the physical effects, ethnic conflicts negatively impact inter-communal relations. Such distrust torpedoes the motivation and the capability of the communities to cooperate for peaceful coexistence.

The participants agreed that poverty has been a major cause of interethnic conflict in the border area. In both Nyakach Sub County and Sigowet-Soin Sub County poverty level is above 30%. Poverty has life altering consequences. Participants spoke of how poverty prevents them from providing adequate education for their children, who are typically compelled to drop out of school, as their parents cannot afford the uniforms and school supplies. Those youth may then be forced to engage in casual labour such as construction labourers, house maids, quarry workers etc, which offer meagre daily wages. Such youth therefore are susceptible to bad influence and are at the service of businesspeople organizing cattle rustling for monetary gains. Moreover, poverty also swells the number of jobless youths who are often used by politicians to cause mayhem in the borderlands for their own political interest. Some of participants mentioned that they live from hand to mouth whether at the village or in the nearby townships. This makes feeling empowered impossible. As one participant succinctly remarked, "How can one achieve empowerment if they are constantly struggling to feed their families?" (FGD, January 2026).

Peacebuilding initiatives

Since independence the Luo of Kisumu County and Kipsigis of Kericho County have adopted various mechanisms to deal with border conflict and cattle rustling. First, indigenous peace resolution mechanisms have been promoted (KII08, August, 2025). The council of elders from both Kipsigis and Luo communities have continued to intervene in various conflicts that have occurred in the post-independence period. Most of the respondents affirmed that the elders have been engaged in numerous efforts to resolve the conflicts between the two communities. In both communities the institution of elders is highly revered (KII12, August 2025). Elders are seen as dependable and well-informed individuals on community matters (Tuso & Flaherty, 2016). This enables them to make informed and rational decisions in matters related to peace building and reconciliation.

Traditionally, in the past Luo and Kipsigis leaders often organized conflict resolution and peace-building initiatives. Such peace talks are often held at designated places along the common border. Each community had their elders whom they respected and venerated. The rule of thumb was that the enemy would never kill a leader on a peace mission, however bitter the war had been (Ochola-Ayayo, 1976). To do this would be to bring a curse upon the

community involved. The leader sent usually sought his peer from the opposing community, and delivered the peace message to him. Once delivered, the recipient would convene a meeting with his peers and decide whether to cease hostilities or not. If they decided to cease hostilities, a message would be sent to the other camp to arrange a common meeting. Old men from both sides would sit down to talk. If they agreed, a bull was slaughtered and a meal shared. Once everyone had eaten to their fill, beer was shared from a common pot using reed straws. Both parties then swore that the conflict was resolved. This was the process called **Ng'adoGuok**, i.e. swearing that the conflict was over, and whoever would bring conflict over the same issue be cursed (Ochola-Ayayo, 1976). One of the women leaders shared her experience of a visit by Luo elders to a remote part of Sigowet area to meet their Kipsigis counterparts. The Luo carried a he-goat while the Kipsigis provided "*mursik*" (fermented milk) and the two groups shared a meal to cement the relationship (KII08, August 2025).

The study further established that peacebuilding initiatives by community peace committee in the area have highly contributed to avert escalation of conflicts. The success of the committees is largely because they are acceptable since they comprise individuals known to the community who understand the likely root causes of the conflicts. This finding agrees with earlier studies such as Atieno (2023) that affirmed that local peace committees are more appropriate since all segments of the community are equally represented, thus meeting the needs and aspirations of the community at large.

Religious bodies have also been involved in peaceful intervention whenever serious conflicts occur between the two communities. For instance, National Cohesion and Integration Commission (NCIC), the National Council of Churches of Kenya (NCCK) and the Free Pentecostal Fellowship Church in Kenya based at Thessalia Mission Station Africa in Muhoroni Subcounty have been the vanguard in peace building between Luo of and Kipsigis of the Kisumu-Kericho borderland. Both groups have organized and funded various peace-building activities, which include, but are not limited to sports, peace workshops. They have also participated in post conflict reconstruction by offering guidance and counselling services and material support to violence victims (KII11, August, 2025).

In 2021, 2022 and 2023, Grassroot Impact Centre (GIC), a community-based organization in Nyakach Sub County convened series of faith based and intercommunity peace dialogues between the Luo and Kipsigis communities and other affected stakeholders in Sondu area along Sigowet/Soin Sub County and Nyakach Sub-County border. The series of intercommunity dialogues started with the need to understand the challenges faced by the bordering communities and to facilitate co-generation of appropriate solutions which they could jointly implement to foster lasting peace, livelihoods improvement, and development in general. The series of the intercommunity dialogues focused on the priority areas which the local communities and stakeholders felt were the key foundation/pillars for the other socio-economic and environmental activities to progress.

The ultimate events in 2022 were held for a week in June-July 2022 and on 2nd July 2022 prior to the general elections it yielded the **Kamolok Peace Accord**.

The **Kamolok Peace Accord** was endorsed by community members and stakeholders who attended in thousands on 2nd July 2023 at Kamolok Primary School, Tabaita Sublocation, Kaplelartet Ward, Sigowet-Soin Sub-County, Kericho County. The event aimed at strengthening peace and coexistence among the two bordering communities before, during, and after the then upcoming general elections. **Kamolok Peace Accord** was endorsed by the local communities, women and youth groups, council of elders of Nyakach and Kericho county, religious leaders, professionals, leaders of various sector associations, the National Government Administrative Officers (NGAOs), National Police Service (NPS), politicians. The series of peace building events included the interdenominational prayers; intercultural Games/Sports; mentorship of girls & boys from Sondu area; peace training for community leaders; elders' meetings incorporating exchange of cultural ideas and general peacebuilding talks by elders; ICT training for youth sponsored by Karura Chapel-Nairobi; peace caravan & peace awareness and sensitization; music concerts and presentations by neighbouring schools. During the event Luo and Kipsigis elders dressed in traditional regalia addressed the participants and performed traditional peacemaking rituals. As a result of the event, the borderland did not witness any cases of violence during and after the 2022 general elections as had been the case in previous elections since 1992. As such, community peace dialogue forums have contributed to lowering tensions and enmity between the two communities through constant interactions and exchanges.

In the FGD it emerged that the peace committees have been instrumental in minimizing tensions arising from the border issue. As one FGD member vividly articulated:

As evident in their compositions, local peace committees represent both communities (Nyakach and Sigowet-Soin). These committees play a key role in mitigating conflicts by reconciling conflicting parties especially where incidents of cattle theft have taken place. In most cases, the committee members, due to the fact that they live in the villages, have been used to recover stolen animals (FGD, January 2026).

It can be deduced from the statement from the FGD that local peace committee members tend to act as village watchdogs. They help in recovery of stolen livestock as well as helping to reconcile the parties. This is an important undertaking since it reduces tensions between contesting parties in the two areas.

The role of women in peacebuilding

Women play a pivotal role in the rural economy of the two sub-counties, especially in the form of petty-trade. Women, however, face enormous economic obstacles in their economic and business endeavors. The material conditions under which most women live and operate continue to deteriorate due to economic and social factors such as the prevailing economic doldrums in the country, interethnic and politically instigated conflicts in the borderlands. Poverty in both sub-counties is increasing at an alarming rate. Women constitute the majority of the poor and illiterate in the two sub counties (2019 Population Census). In addition, almost half of the households in Nyakach Sub County are headed by women (KIPPRA, 2024).

This study revealed that Luo and Kipsigis women have played a major role in peace building activities. The participation of these women in peace building has increased gradually since the 1990s. Over the years both Luo and Kipsigis women have initiated and are currently implementing several peacebuilding initiatives to mitigate the conflict between the two communities. While many studies show that conflict occurs with the involvement or acquiescence of women, several studies portray women as the principal driving force in peace initiatives (UNESCO, 2002). Women generally show a keen interest in peace processes. However, during peace negotiations and peacebuilding talks women are largely sidelined ostensibly because of myriad social, cultural, economic, and political constraints (KII07, August, 2025). Several respondents called for gender mainstreaming in all peace building and reconciliation processes in the borderland. The findings concur with Solomon (1999) who has observed that a few women participate in peace building and reconciliation process and peace talks aimed at preventing and resolving conflicts. He further asserts that despite their contributions in provision and nurturing, women's efforts are ignored, rarely recognized and all together not rewarded. Yet women contribute a highly motivated and able group of stakeholders for peace building.

The findings of this study indicate that members of Luo and Kipsigis communities are usually affected by recurrent border conflicts. While entire communities suffer the consequences of conflict, women and girls are particularly affected because of their status in society and their sex (Akinyi et al., 2011). Available statistics indicate that approximately 80% of civilian casualties in armed conflicts are women and that 80% of all refugees and internally displaced people worldwide are women and children (UNFPA, 2002). Karimi (2018) in his work titled Rural Women Peace Link (RWPL) observes that the National Council of Churches in Kenya (NCCK) has created spaces for local women to engage and participate in peace and development processes. One key informant affirmed that “women act as ambassadors and encourage reconciliation, youth engage in sport tournaments while traditional leaders mobilize communities and bless peace agreements (KII09, August 2025).

Similarly, another informant affirmed that the youth can contribute to peacebuilding as follows, “the youth can mobilize peers against violence and organize sporting events; elders provide direction and conduct mediation; women provide moral and spiritual support” (KII07, August 2025). Along the same line another informant averred that “women participate in organizing peacebuilding events, men mediate and provide wise counsel as the youth are expected to lead in implementation and campaign against violence” (KII08, August 2025).

One significant challenge to the empowerment of women and their involvement in active peace building initiatives came out strongly in the FGD. Several participants stated that there are some men who are still conservative and have not changed their views on women, they don't allow their wives to engage in any activity outside the domestic sphere hence the small numbers of women attending community peacebuilding forums. The participants explained that this reflects the need for more education for men to teach them about gender equality laws and women's rights under the new constitution (FGD, January 2026).

The role of the youth

It was observed during field work of the need for inclusivity of marginalized groups in peacebuilding. As one respondent succinctly puts it, "the dialogue forums should ensure bringing the youth on board and giving them the room to speak up their minds and share their interests" (KII3, August 2025). Moreover, as one of the elders affirmed, "community peace dialogues creates a harmonious environment for a thriving economy" (KII01, August 2025). A youth leader and key informant opined, "I can suggest that Grassroot Impact Centre involves and invest more in the youth because they are the people who normally fuel conflict" (KII14). He further asserted that, "we the youth have a role to play in shaping the peace desires and we should never be ignored" (KII14, January 2025).

Several informants made suggestions on how to address the Sondu conflict thus, "the best solution is to create job opportunities for the youth, conduct evangelism to spread the gospel, sensitization on citizen patriotism and making Sondu a town/municipal council" (KII07, August 2025). Another informant asserted that "the best solutions include joint socio-economic projects that make the communities depend on each other/collaboration; make clear demarcation of administrative boundaries" (KII10, August 2025).

Participants also gave their views during the FGD on what should be done to uplift the youth so that they can overcome poverty and discard the culture of violence. First, financial independence can minimize cycles of dependency and violence. Basic skills training programs in motor mechanics, building, plumbing, entrepreneurship can provide individuals with the essential practical skills required for workforce success. In addition, courses in agriculture, tailoring, or digital literacy equip the youth with the knowledge and skills necessary to jump start their enterprises or obtain employment. Microfinance support such as loans, grants, or savings groups, can provide individuals with start-up financial resources necessary to initiate or grow their enterprises. These initiatives can surely promote individual self-sufficiency, enhance livelihoods, and torpedo cycles of poverty and violence. GIC has embarked on some of these programs. By focusing on more vulnerable individuals, including women and youth, such initiatives can make it possible for individuals to reconstruct their lives and enhance the economic well-being of their communities.

Impact of community dialogue

The findings of this study indicate that members of the two communities are usually affected by recurrent border conflicts, especially in Upper Nyakach in Kisumu County and Sigowet-Soin in Kericho County. While entire communities suffer the consequences of conflict, women and girls are particularly affected because of their status in society and their sex (Akinyi et al., 2011). Indeed, available statistics indicate that approximately 80% of civilian casualties in armed conflicts are women and that 80% of all refugees and internally displaced people worldwide are women and children (UNPF, 2002). Moreover, women find themselves in a serious situation: while they are the main civilian victims of conflicts, they are often powerless to prevent them, are often excluded from negotiations when it comes to their resolutions and confined to a marginal role in the post-conflict reconstruction and reconciliation efforts (Akinyi et al., 2011).

One participant expressed how being a widow as a result of the interethnic violence has been a hinderance to their own socioeconomic advancement: "For me, I believe I am capable of managing a small business, but because of

poverty in terms of lack of capital and heading a household alone makes it hard for me. On the other hand, if I got capital I can somehow empower myself and my family as well” (FGD, January 2026).

One of the key informants observed that “usually community peace dialogues draw people from both conflicting sides, they collaborate with NGOs, government agencies and other private peacebuilders and conduct an exercise that fosters peace (KII10, August 2025). Another key informant asserted that “community dialogue forums restore trust between the two communities through face to face discussion; promote coexistence through cultural interactions” (KII15, August 2025). On the same vein, it was noted that “community peace dialogues can create harmony and spur economic growth hence contributing to SDGs” (KIII5, August 2025). Observable achievements of community peace dialogues included “reduced crossborder attacks, increased market interaction at Sondu, and formation of joint policing groups” (KIII5, August 2025).

There is a strong nexus between peace and SDG as one key informant affirmed, “absence of peace scares away investors thus derailing SDGs, absence of peace forces people to relocate, absence of peace sabotages economic growth”(KII14, August 2025). At the same time, another participant and Sondu violence survivor asserted that, “definitely when there is violence most properties get damaged, leading to destruction and stunted development” (KIII3, January 2026). A church leader and participant noted that, “community peace dialogue creates a peaceful environment for social development.” (KIII2, January 2026). Basically, community dialogue forums “can create peaceful and harmonious coexistence and spur economic growth thus enhancing livelihoods” (KII07, August 2026). Furthermore, the informant posited that, “the absence of peace derails achievements of SDGs (KII07, August 2025) while another informant averred that “GIC has trained peace ambassadors, donated funds to support peacebuilding initiatives” (KII03, August 2025).

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. The National and county government has the final responsibility to settle the boundary dispute and also sensitizing local residents about the boundary. The two county governments should come up with a clear policy in consultation with the two communities on how the revenue collected from Sondu market will be shared.
Educational initiatives and public awareness campaigns are vital instruments for transforming societal norms and mitigating violence. The government ought to employ local or vernacular media campaigns to engage a broad audience via television, radio, social media, and community platforms. These campaigns can be used to disseminate narratives of survivors, underscore the catastrophic effects of interethnic violence. To cultivate respect and non-violent conflict resolution from an early age, gender equality, and national cohesion should be incorporated into educational curricula. Human rights education should be promoted to empower students, overcome detrimental stereotypes, and foster positive social change.
2. The two county governments should facilitate community dialogues, including *barazas* (open-air meetings) and workshops, that foster open discussions regarding violence, its effects, and avenues for assistance. Governments should collaborate with religious leaders, local officials, and community leaders. These dialogues should promote coexistence, confront negative norms, and stimulate collaborative efforts to avert interethnic conflict and violence.
3. The youth have not been fully incorporated in peace-building initiatives, yet they are major players in the conflict. This state of affairs should be addressed for effectiveness of peace building in the borderland.

4. The two communities could still apply some aspects of their indigenous methods of conflict resolution and peacemaking which are not repugnant to “social morality” and could still meet the needs of the society. Since the causal factors of most of these conflicts are deeply rooted in the peoples' cultures, appropriate conflict resolution mechanisms must incorporate the local cultures, particularly indigenous peace-making processes. Hence the need to strengthen traditional conflict resolution mechanisms such as community peace dialogues and linking them with formal judicial and state systems.
5. NGOs and CBOs should also engage in more civic education to equip the two communities with knowledge and information on devolution, resource sharing and management and the need for peaceful co-existence. It's important to promote conflict resolution skills acquisition in the community. Empowering individuals with skills to resolve conflicts non-violently is crucial for personal and communal harmony. Conflict resolution training equips individuals with essential skills for effective communication, negotiation, and de-escalation of situations. These training sessions can tackle prevalent sources of conflict in numerous communities by concentrating on land disputes and interethnic conflict dynamics. Instructions on basic stress management techniques, including mindfulness, relaxation exercises, and problem-solving skills, can assist individuals in regulating their emotions and addressing conflict in a more balanced way. By cultivating these skills, individuals can reduce the probability of engaging in violence and foster amicable dispute resolution.
6. Religious institutions and their leaders should continue to play a more significant role in resolving conflict between the two communities by adopting more proactive measures. This could include joint initiatives and prayer rallies aimed at promoting peaceful coexistence. Religious and community leaders are influential within the community and serve as primary educators. Utilizing the authority of religious and community leaders is essential to confront negative stereotypes and promote transformation. Providing training and capacity-building programs is essential to equip these leaders with the requisite knowledge and skills to tackle the effects of interethnic conflict and violence and land-related conflicts. Integrating peace and coexistence messages into sermons, community *barazas*, and customary ceremonies, they shape public opinion and change negative narratives. In sum, religious and traditional leaders should effectively use their influence and authority to foster a more just and peaceful society.

CONCLUSION

The study concludes that the government has failed over the years to address the boundary issue in an amicable manner further fueling tension between the two communities. Failure to include the two groups and incorporate their views on the best ways possible to demarcate the final boundary has continued to polarize the relationship the more. This study further concludes that a lasting solution to the conflict is possible through the activities of community peace dialogue committees which has remained steadfast as they engage with various stakeholders including national government officers to find a lasting solution. The study additionally concludes that community-led peace networks have been important in the area for their role in peace advocacy and communication.

Local politicians, especially members of parliament and members of county assemblies, tend to inflame the conflict i.e. politicizing the issue by inciting their community members thus torpedoing conflict resolution initiatives.

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APPENDICES

ARIN MINI-GRANTS PROJECT 2025

Appendix 1: Interview Schedule for all Participants

The contribution of community peace dialogues to peacebuilding and sustainable development in East Africa: A case study of peacebuilding among the Luo and Kipsigis of Kisumu and Kericho Counties

The purpose of this interview schedule is to collect data on “The contribution of community peace dialogues in peacebuilding and sustainable development among the Luo and Kipsigis of Kisumu and Kericho Counties in Kenya.”

The researcher assures you that the information gathered will be treated with utmost confidentiality and for academic purposes only.

Section A: General Information

1. What is your name?

Full Names:

2. What is your gender?

- Male
- Female
- Other
- If other, please specify

3. What is your age bracket?

18 to 35yrs	36 to 50yrs
51 to 69yrs	Above 70yrs

4. What is your occupation?

Employed	Farmer	Self-Employed
Unemployed	Retired	Others

- If others, please specify

5. What is your marital status?

Married	Single	Widowed
Divorced	Separated	

6. What is your highest level of Education?

University/College	High School
Primary School	No Formal Education

- 7. Name of the Village/town:.....Location:**
Ward:..... Sub County:.....
County:.....
Interview Date:.....

Section B: Kenyan grassroot communities use of peace dialogues in Social Development Goals (SDGs) Governance and Coordination in Kenya.

- a) The Luo and Kipsigis living along the Kisumu and Kericho Counties' border have experienced episodic conflicts and violence along their common border for many years, what do you think are the main causes of these conflicts?
- b) What are the characteristics of these conflicts/violence?
- c) What have been the impact of these conflicts/violence?
- d) Please describe the general relationship between the Luo and the Kipsigis living along the Kericho-Kisumu common border?
- e) What are community peace dialogues?
- f) How is the local community peace dialogues organized?
- g) Can you share your experience on any past peacebuilding initiatives to resolve the Luo-Kipsigis conflict over the years?
- h) How successful were such peacebuilding efforts?
- i) What were the challenges you encountered in such peacebuilding initiatives?
- e) What indicators would you use to measure the success of community peace dialogues in handling the Luo-Kipsigis conflict?

Section C: The effectiveness of community peace dialogue in promoting SDG Governance and coordination in Africa

- a) What are your views on the argument that SDGs cannot be achieved when there is no peace in the community?
- b) In what ways is community peace dialogue being used to promote Social Development Goals in the local community?
- c) What are the challenges of using community peace dialogues in peacebuilding in the Luo-Kipsigis conflict?
- d) What do you suggest is the best solution to the protracted Luo-Kipsigis conflict?
- e) How can we apply SDG 16 which focuses on promoting just, peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development 'for all' by 2030 in your community?

Section D: Opportunities of using community peace dialogues for strengthening the alignment of SDG Governance and coordination in Africa.

- i) How can community peace dialogues facilitate alignment between local communities, government institutions, civil society, and private sector actors?
- ii) How can community peace dialogues influence progress across interlinked SDGs, e.g. m SDG 2 (food security and land use), SDG 6 (equitable water resource management), and SDG 16 (peace and institutional accountability)?
- iii) What are the contributions of the diverse stakeholders in the peace dialogues, e.g. women, youth, elders, and traditional leaders, in peacebuilding activities in Kisumu and Kericho Counties?
- iv) Suggest how the government and private sectors could collaborate in implementing SDGs programs.

Section E: The impact of community peace dialogue forums in post-conflict reconciliation process in Kenya.

- a) What's the impact of community peace dialogue in post-conflict reconciliation process between the Luo and the Kipsigis?

- b) How can community peace dialogues influence policy change towards addressing conflicts and violence in Kenya?
- c) How can community peace dialogues be used to ensure the inclusion of marginalized voices such as women and the youth in peacebuilding initiatives?
- d) What has been some of the observable achievements of community peace dialogues in addressing the Luo-Kipsigis conflict?
- e) In what ways has Grassroot Impact Centre been involved in community peace dialogue over the Luo-Kipsigis conflicts?
- f) What suggestions can you offer to Grassroot Impact Centre in its attempt to address the Luo-Kipsigis conflict?
- g) Anything else that you want to add?

Thank you so much for your cooperation.

Appendix 2: Focus Group Discussion Guide

Section A: Kenyan grassroot communities use of peace dialogues in Social Development Goals (SDGs) Governance and Coordination in Kenya.

- i) In what ways is community peace dialogue being used to promote understanding and coexistence between the Luo and Kipsigis living along the Kisumu- Kericho border?
- ii) How has community peace dialogues enabled your community to participate in peacebuilding initiatives in the area?

Section B: The effectiveness of community peace dialogue in promoting SDG Governance and Coordination in Kenya

- i) Kisumu and Kericho Counties have experienced episodic conflicts and violence for many years, what do you think are the main causes of these conflicts?
- ii) Share with us any earlier attempts to address the Luo-Kipsigis conflicts and its outcome.
- iii) In your own opinion how can these conflicts be effectively addressed?
- iv) What role should the government play in promoting peace and security along the Kisumu- Kericho border?
- v) How has GIC engaged in peacebuilding activities along the Kisumu- Kericho border.
- vi) What are the challenges of using community peace dialogues in peacebuilding in the community?

Section C: Opportunities of using community peace dialogues for strengthening the alignment of SDG Governance and coordination in Africa.

- v) What are the contributions of women and youth in the peace dialogues in your community?
- vi) What are the challenges faced by women and youth in community peace dialogues and how can such challenges be overcome?

Section D: The impact of community peace dialogue forums in post-conflict reconciliation process in Africa.

- i) What's the impact of community peace dialogue in post-conflict reconciliation process in your community?
- ii) What are the advantages of using community peace dialogues in addressing the Luo-Kipsigis conflict along the Kisumu-Kericho border?

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